

and by nationalist politicians opposed to his rule, he abandoned his palace in order to launch a campaign for full independence from France, successfully placing himself at the head of a popular anticolonial movement.

France bows out

By the end of 1953, France had ceded effective independence to the royal governments in Laos and Cambodia. Sihanouk proved an able politician. In 1955, he abdicated in order to become prime minister. Cambodia entered a period of fragile peace and mild prosperity, but Laos was not so fortunate. The Pathet Lao, backed by newly independent North Vietnam, were able to control large areas of the country, engaging in a civil war with the government. The government armed Hmong (Miao) mountain tribesmen as guerrillas to fight the Pathet Lao and received increasing military support from the United States.



Hmong fighters

The United States trained and armed Hmong mountain tribesmen in remote areas of Laos to fight against the North Vietnamese and Pathet Lao guerrillas. The Hmong were motivated by a traditional hostility to the Vietnamese.

“The **king may be mad**, but it is a **brilliant** sort of **madness**.”

FRENCH GENERAL PAUL GIROD DE LANGLADE ON CAMBODIAN KING NORODOM SIHANOUK, 1953